

MUSIC FOR HOLY WEEK

Good morning to all the music maestros and enthusiasts in the house. It gives me great joy and privilege to talk us through music for/in Holy Week. It is important to state clearly at the very beginning that:

1. No one knows it all.
2. The song selections are at best seen as SUGGESTIONS.

I would be speaking to us based on my experience and exposure as a choirmaster and music director, my training as a catholic priest and of cause, common sense knowledge.

My sources are:

1. The Roman Missal (Sacramentary)
2. Class notes on Liturgy
3. Internet (LiturgyTools.net and CERC)
4. The daily Missal

Before we forge ahead, we need to understand and clarify certain terms or at best, refresh our memories on what we already know. The first question is...**what is Holy Week?**

In plain language, Holy Week is the week before Easter, the week leading up to the great celebration of Easter; beginning with **PALM SUNDAY** and ending on **HOLY SATURDAY**. In the words of Ogar Thomas (a friend), it is the week that changed the world. Within this week, we celebrate the Sacred Triduum; Holy Thursday, Good Friday and Holy Saturday.

Holy Week is most definitely a very sacred time of the year, for it is now that we will commemorate and remember the last week of Jesus' life on this earth. These are the days leading up to the great Easter Feast. The Lenten season of sacrifice and self-denial is about to come to an end, but this coming week is extremely important for all Christians. The greatest focus of the week is the Passion (suffering), death and Resurrection of Jesus Christ and the events that led up to it.

Those who engage themselves wholeheartedly in living the entire paschal cycle (Lent, Triduum and Easter's Fifty Days) discover that it can change them forever. This is especially so of the Triduum which, standing at the heart of the Easter season, is an intense immersion in the fundamental mystery of what it is to be Christian. During these days, we suffer with Christ so that we might rise with Him at His glorious Resurrection. Holy Week is a time to clear our schedules of unnecessary activities. Our minds and hearts should be fixed on Jesus and what He did for us. Let us bear the Cross so that may be worthy of wearing the crown He wore.

The Rubrics in the Roman Missal clearly emphasizes the **need and importance** of music and singing during this period. In no.2 of its instruction on the celebration of the **Sacred Triduum**, it states;

“For a fitting celebration of the Sacred Triduum, a sufficient number of lay ministers is required, who must be **carefully instructed as to what they are to do**. The singing of the people, the ministers, and the **Priest Celebrant** has a **special importance** in the celebration of these days, **for when texts are sung, they have their proper impact**...Pastors should...as best as they can prepare the people for active and fruitful participation”.

Notice that I highlighted certain points in the above quote. This is to emphasize;

1. The importance of **effective communication with the Minister** before any of the ceremonies to avoid mix up and confusion during the ceremonies. The onus is on the priest to meet with the lay minister BUT...if Moses does not go to the mountain, The Mountain should please go to Moses.
2. The importance of music during this period and precisely good music with the right selection and rendition.

Having refreshed our minds and established certain foundations, we can now look at song selections and singing generally in Holy Week. We might have the right selections and not sing well, we might sing very well albeit the wrong selections (e.g Hallelujah Chorus on Good Friday). The two must marry each other; right selection of songs and good singing. As regards singing generally in Holy Week, I can only mention based on my limited knowledge that we train our choirs to;

1. Understand the week we are about entering and what role it plays in the life of the church and the individual. A short liturgy seminar with your priest could suffice even if it's just for an hour during the course of the week before Holy Week.
2. Learn simple basics in interpreting Music. For example, you cannot be singing *The old rugged cross* on Good Friday and running at an allegretto speed with an *ff* volume...haba!
3. Immerse ourselves into the music and allow ourselves to be consumed by what we are singing. We could recite the text of each hymn before singing it (it works like magic).

PALM SUNDAY

On this day, the church recalls **the entrance of Christ the lord into Jerusalem** to accomplish his **paschal mystery**. Accordingly, the memorial of this entrance of the Lord takes place at all Masses, by means of the procession or the solemn entrance before the principal Mass or the simple entrance before other Masses. The key words are Entrance of Christ the Lord into Jerusalem...as what? As king of course but, *a servant king*! To what purpose? To celebrate his **PASCHAL MYSTERY** (passion, death and resurrection).

This now guides our selections. The following hymns would be suitable for Palm Sunday;

1. Hosanna filio David (when we gather at the point the procession would commence from)
2. Crown him with many crowns
3. Give me joy in my heart(Tune-SING HOSANNA)
4. At the name of Jesus(Caroline noel...Meter 6.5.6.5 D)
5. From heaven you came(Graham KENDRICK)
6. All hail the power of Jesus name
7. From Salem's Plains
8. Children of Jerusalem(meter 7.7.7.7) john HENLEY
9. O Sacred head now wounded
10. All glory laud and honor
11. Ride on, ride on in Majesty

HOLY THURSDAY/MAUNDY THURSDAY

Ideally, this day begins with Chrism Mass in the morning and ends with the Mass of the Lord's Supper in the evening. However, for pastoral reasons, precisely due to the vast nature of our dioceses, the Bishop celebrates Chrism Mass either on Tuesday or Wednesday of Holy Week so priests can attend and travel back to their places of pastoral assignment.

On this day, three major themes suffices during the Liturgy;

1. Institution of the Eucharist
2. Institution of the Ministerial Priesthood
3. Commandment of the Lord concerning Fraternal Charity

During the mass of the Lord's Supper, the Gloria is **said/sung**. It is important to note that after the Gloria, the Organ and other musical instruments **MAY** be used only as **to support the singing**. After the homily, the ceremony of washing of feet follows (as directed and practiced within your local church). During this ceremony these songs can be sung;

1. The antiphons given in the Roman Missal
2. Lord do you wash my feet (plenty versions available)
3. Servant king

Now, it is important to note that the ***ubi caritas*** chant/hymn or **Where true love is dwelling** hymn is sung at the beginning of the liturgy of the Eucharist i.e. when the gifts (bread and wine) are been brought to the Altar.

Permit me to state here clearly that there is a popular song by one of us titled *ubi caritas*. A very beautiful piece but the lyrics are actually SUITABLE for washing of feet. The hymn *Ubi caritas* means where there is charity and love, God is there.

Other songs recommended on this day are:

1. This is my will
2. Come lets share in the banquet
3. Let us break bread together
4. Sweet sacrament Divine
5. What wondrous love is this
6. Praise to the holiest in the height
7. I am the bread of life
8. Soul of my savior
9. I trusted even when I said
10. Priestly people
11. *Nos Autem* (when the priest venerates the altar and begins incensation)

Now, at the end of Mass, there is a transfer of the Most Blessed Sacrament to a place of repose. This procession at the end of Mass to the Altar of repose replaces the normal recession at the end of Mass. During this procession led by the Priest with the Blessed Sacrament, the choir takes the hymn *Pange, lingua* (exclusive of the last two stanzas). If the choir does not know this hymn, then another Eucharistic Chant is sung. The choir could use:

1. O Jesus we adore Thee who in thy love Divine (Meter 7.6.7.6, Text: Irvin Udulutsch)
2. Sweet Sacrament Divine

When the procession reaches the place of repose, the priest places the Ciborium in the tabernacle (the door of which remains open) and then he incenses the Blessed Sacrament. During the incensation, the hymn *Tantum ergo Sacramentum* or another **Eucharistic Chant** is sung. After a period of adoration and silence, the priest leaves to the sacristy while private adorations continue.

GOOD FRIDAY

Before I say a word on this ceremony, permit me to **strongly** suggest that we as choristers should take charge of the singing of the *Stabat Mater* (At the cross her station keeping...) at the passion play in the morning of Good Friday. Most times we leave it to **people of goodwill/morning mass congregation** and often times they make a mess of it. The choir should be able to lead in the singing at the passion play. (No excuses can suffice because it's a public holiday. For those

that do business and are tempted to go and open shop, I ask; can you open your shop or go about your business on the day you lose your father?)

On Good Friday, we celebrate the passion and death of Jesus. On this day and the following day, the church doesn't celebrate the Sacraments at all, **EXCEPT** for *Penance and Anointing of the Sick*. We do not have Mass on this day, just a celebration of the Lord's Passion and it consists of three parts namely

1. The liturgy of the Word
2. The Adoration of the Cross
3. Holy Communion

It is important to state categorically that **SILENCE** is an **essential part** of this ceremony. Silence from within to without.

The ceremony begins with a silent procession by the ministers to the Altar. They either kneel/prostrate at the sanctuary while others kneel. After a silent prayer, the priest goes to his chair and says the prayer omitting the invitation LET US PRAY. What follows is the liturgy of the word (May I suggest strongly that the psalm be in plain chant and possibly without accompaniment) which ends with the Solemn Intercessions.

The second part of the ceremony begins with the Showing of the Holy Cross and subsequently, Adoration of the Cross. During the adoration of the Holy Cross, the choir should sing any of the following:

1. ***Crucem tuam adoramus***(we adore your cross o lord)
2. **The Reproaches** (my people, what have I done to you...)
3. ***Crux fidelis*** (Faithful Cross)

It is important to note that when singing the hymn FAITHFUL CROSS, the conclusion part of it **MUST NEVER BE OMITTED**.

Also, the *Stabat Mater* **MAY** be sung in **accord with local circumstance or popular traditions**. The *Stabat Mater* hymn is done in memory of the compassion of the Blessed Virgin Mary (Again, we should remember this is optional please).

After the adoration of the Holy Cross comes the third and final part of the ceremony; Holy Communion. When the priest goes to bring the Blessed Sacrament from the Altar of Repose to the Altar, it is done in silence without singing. Now, we might have a small challenge here as we know that in most places, Offertory is done after the Adoration of the Holy Cross and during offertory, we sing. Please follow the instruction of the priest in charge but know that the moment he goes to the Altar of Repose, there should be silence. After reception of Holy Communion and the prayer, we genuflect to the cross and depart in **stunned silence!**

The following hymns can be used on Good Friday:

1. The old rugged cross
2. O come and mourn with me
3. Glory be to Jesus
4. That man of Calvary
5. Were you there
6. When I survey the wondrous cross
7. There's a green hill far away
8. And can it be
9. O cross of Christ
10. My suffering Jesus(Jude Nnam)
11. Draw me nearer

HOLY SATURDAY

On this day, the Church waits at the Lord's tomb in prayer and fasting, meditating on his passion and Death and on his Descent into Hell. The choir has the following basic roles to play:

1. Chanting the Exultet (in cases where there is no deacon assigned to your parish and the priest cannot do it)
2. Chanting the Psalms during the readings (I strongly suggest we use plain chants)
3. Chanting the litany of saints
4. Leading the congregation in singing the Easter songs

The following hymns are suitable for Holy Saturday:

1. Low in the grave
2. Hallelujah! What a savior
3. Jesus is Risen
4. The Easter song (my lord he died for a kingdom)
5. All creatures of our God
6. Alleluia, sing to Jesus
7. Christ our Pasch
8. Hail the day that see him rise
9. Vidi aquam (sprinkling of water after Baptism/renewal of baptismal promises)
10. Come to the springs of living water

RECOMMENDATION

I would strongly recommend we liaise with our priests to produce a bulletin for Holy Week. A bulletin that contains the songs (texts only) we intend to sing during the week. If we can give it out for a little token, the people would be happy to buy. The Latin chants should

have their translations by their side so the people understand and relate to what they are singing. If we have projectors in our churches, its fine but having a bulletin for holy week is just perfect. Again, please discuss with your parish priest.

Conclusion

In conclusion, I would say that, in as much as a lot has been said during this interaction, we must be conscious of the fact that **we need to be in sync with the priest to have a wonderful ceremony**. If he does not take it upon himself to have a small liturgy practice with us, we should **amicably** draw his attention to it, that way, all of us will be in sync and worship of God will be glorious. Also, the songs listed above **are not Absolutes or Obligatory, liturgy is always dynamic**. These songs should serve as **guides** to us. **The most important thing is understanding the ceremonies and knowing what is suitable for it**. We should not forget that the chorister is first, a Christian and disciple. While we lead others to God via our singing, we should not be left behind. THANKS FOR READING.

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